



Ministry of Housing,
Communities &
Local Government

Development Management Software Funding (DMSF) update: What we are learning about implementing the Open Data Standards

Digital Planning Team

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What we are learning about implementing the Open Data Standards

There isn't a Planning Data community session this month (Sept 2026), so we wanted to share an update on the Development Management Software Fund (DMSF) work and what we are learning about implementing the planning application data standards in practice.

Over the past few weeks, four LPA and software-supplier pairings have been working through a practical question:

What would it actually take for LPAs and their software suppliers to publish the National Public View consistently?

The National Public View defines the records and fields from the wider planning application data specification that should be published as open data. The separate update, [Refining the planning application data specification](#), explains this distinction and describes how the specification, guidance and examples have evolved through recent implementation feedback.

DMSF is approaching the same challenge from the implementation side: taking the National Public View and comparing it with the data, terminology and structures that exist in current planning software and LPA processes.

What the mapping work has involved

Each of the four LPA/supplier pairings has worked through the National Public View against an existing back-office system.

That has meant getting into quite detailed questions: whether the required information already exists; where it is held; whether local system values correspond to the standard values; whether information is structured in the way the specification expects; and what would need to change for an LPA or its software supplier to consistently output the information in the structure, format and values required by the standard.

Across the four exercises, this has generated more than 100 questions and observations.

The number itself is less important than what the exercise is allowing us to understand. As we consolidate the findings, the issues broadly fall into four areas.

1. Specification, guidance and examples

Some questions arose because a definition, relationship or requirement in the specification wasn't sufficiently clear when people tried to apply it to real data.

This is an important part of the DMSF work. Testing implementation has provided evidence back into data design about where people need clearer definitions, guidance, examples or, occasionally, a change to the specification itself.

A number of those issues have already been addressed. The separate [Refining the planning application data specification](#) report describes this work in detail, including clearer requirement levels, guidance on linked applications and timelines, changes around decisions and conditions, document publication and improved worked examples.

Rather than repeat those changes here, the important DMSF finding is that **implementation testing is actively helping to improve the specification and the material around it.**

2. Mapping and configuration

A second group of questions isn't necessarily about changing the standard at all.

Planning systems and LPAs already hold much of the information required, but may describe or structure it differently. For example, a system may use its own values where the specification expects a value from a defined codelist.

The implementation question then becomes: **can the existing value be reliably mapped to the standard value?**

This distinction matters. If something can be addressed through mapping or configuration, implementation may not require a fundamental change to the underlying product or data collection process.

The specification update explains why defined values and codelists are important: using agreed values rather than different local labels means data from different authorities can be understood consistently.

DMSF is helping us understand the practical work needed to make that consistency possible.

3. Product or data changes

Other requirements may not be achievable simply through mapping.

The information might not currently be captured in a structured form, relationships between records may not exist in the way required by the specification, or a software product may not currently support producing the required output.

These are potentially **product or data changes**.

Identifying these separately is important because it starts to give us a much better picture of what implementation of the standards could mean for software suppliers and LPAs, rather than treating every difference between an existing system and the specification as the same kind of problem.

It also helps distinguish relatively straightforward implementation work from changes that may need product development, changes to data models or changes to how information is recorded during the planning process.

4. Remaining implementation questions and barriers

Finally, there are questions where we still need to establish whether the issue sits with the specification, the software, existing LPA practice or a wider dependency.

These are particularly useful findings.

The purpose of DMSF isn't to assume that LPAs and their existing software already capture and structure all the information needed for the National Public View in a way that can simply be published to the standard. It is to understand what implementation requires in practice: both the changes needed to existing data, systems and processes to meet the standard, and what is needed to publish that data consistently as part of the National Public View.

Where a participating LPA or supplier believes a requirement still cannot practically be met, we want to understand **what specifically prevents it**.

That gives us something concrete to investigate rather than simply recording a requirement as "not supported".

From 100+ questions to an implementation picture

We have now consolidated the questions and observations from the four pairings.

This means each participating LPA and supplier can see the **full range of questions raised across the exercise**, rather than only those identified through their own system.

We're asking them to review that consolidated picture against the latest specification, guidance and examples and help us establish:

- which questions are now answered by the updated specification or supporting material;
- which remaining points are primarily mapping or configuration issues;
- which would require a product or data change;
- which still require clarification; and
- whether anything would prevent practical implementation, and if so, what the specific barrier is.

This prioritisation is deliberate.

Before considering larger product changes or concluding that a requirement is difficult to implement, we first need to remove questions that have already been resolved through the evolving specification and identify things that can be handled through mapping or configuration.

What remains should give us a much stronger evidence base for understanding where genuine product changes, data changes or wider interventions may be required.

A feedback loop between standards and implementation

One of the most useful things emerging from DMSF is therefore the feedback loop between designing the standards and trying to implement them.

Specification → implementation testing → questions and evidence → improvements and clarification → reassessment → clearer implementation requirements

The specification work and DMSF are two sides of that process.

The **Refining the planning application data specification** report sets out how the specification itself has evolved as a result of this kind of evidence.

The DMSF work is now taking the next step: understanding what remains once those specification questions are resolved, and what LPAs, suppliers and the wider planning data ecosystem would actually need to do to implement the National Public View consistently.

What happens next

Through September, our focus is on working through the consolidated findings with participating LPAs and suppliers.

The aim is not simply to close a list of 100+ questions. It is to turn that detailed work into a clearer picture of **which National Public View requirements LPAs and suppliers can meet using their existing data and systems; which require mapping or configuration; which require changes to software, data or processes; and which cannot yet be implemented without further decisions or clarification.**

That will give us a much stronger basis for understanding what implementation of the National Public View will require beyond the individual DMSF pairings, and where future work needs to be focused.

We'll share further findings with the Planning Data community as that picture develops.